the match and, you know, I think he was just very, very sad that we had drawn and ended up going out of the tournament. He burst out crying after his speech.

But the 1999 Proteas squad was just a great team – no, a fantastic team. I still think it was the team with which South Africa had the best chance of winning the World Cup. With all those guys in their prime – Donald, Pollock, Kirsten, Klusener, Cullinan, Cronjé – it was a wonderful one-day outfit. The way in which we'd lost that semi-final was just – excuse my language – fucking tragic.

**The 2003 World Cup**

This game was a totally different story. Eric Simons was now the Proteas coach after taking over from Graham Ford in 2002. Fordie had replaced Bob Woolmer after Bob had resigned in the wake of the dramatic loss discussed above. And then poor Fordie was made the scapegoat for our disastrous tour of Australia in 2001/02, when we were blitzed 0-3 in the Test series.

Anyway, so with Eric now at the helm, things were not looking promising even in the lead-up to the World Cup. We'd lost one or two practice games before the start of the tournament, and there wasn't a hell of a lot of confidence in the camp before our opening game against the West Indies. We tried to make light of our poor performances in those warm-up games, but the fact was that we were a team without proper focus.

The World Cup was being held in South Africa, and, as a result, the team was in constant demand for functions and press calls. There were just too many damn distractions and extra activities throughout the entire tournament, which was one of the reasons the guys would later use as an excuse for our poor performance. Look, I do think they were right, to a certain extent, because there genuinely was a huge demand for our attention, and questions probably did need to be asked of the Proteas management back then. But it didn't really affect me personally. For me, the main problem was that we were just not operating as a team. And it's a problem that has plagued the Proteas ever since. I'll go into more detail in Chapter 10.

I guess some players need to find excuses for poor performances, but I didn't mind how hectic things got. This was a World Cup. Things were